

Cause and Blame

Politicians or the People

by Michael Medley

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Introduction

Every election cycle, Americans express deep frustration with their elected officials. “They don’t listen.” “They’re out of touch.” “They only care about staying in power.” These complaints are so common they’ve become background noise in our political conversations.

Yet a closer look reveals a consistent and uncomfortable pattern: many of the outcomes people blame on politicians are the predictable results of what the public itself demanded.

Consider a familiar example. For years, voters in many communities pressed hard for higher minimum wages, year after year. Candidates who refused to support rapid increases often lost support or were voted out. Politicians who wanted to keep their jobs responded by pushing for wage hikes. Over time, some small businesses found they could no longer afford to operate. Others moved operations overseas or replaced workers with automation. Jobs disappeared. Unemployment rose in certain sectors. Many of the same people who had demanded the wage increases then turned around and blamed politicians for the job losses and economic hardship that followed.

Or consider the growing tension around data centers. Americans want faster internet, better streaming, more powerful AI tools, and seamless cloud services. At the same time, communities across the country are organizing to block the construction of the very data centers that make those technologies possible — citing noise, energy use, water consumption, or changes to the local landscape. When politicians respond to local pressure by slowing or stopping these projects, the same public that wants ever-better technology often ends up frustrated when services lag or innovation slows. Once again, the blame falls on politicians.

These are not isolated incidents. They are symptoms of a deeper disconnect: voters frequently demand short-term benefits or protections without fully understanding the long-term trade-offs and systemic consequences. Politicians, operating in a system that rewards responsiveness to voter pressure, often deliver what is asked for. When the predictable negative outcomes arrive — job losses, higher costs, strained infrastructure, or unintended social effects — the public rarely reflects on its own role in the chain of events. Instead, it blames the politicians who tried to satisfy the original demands.

This book explores that cycle across multiple areas of policy: wages and employment, energy and infrastructure, housing, healthcare, education, immigration, entitlements, public safety, and foreign policy. In each case, we will examine real patterns of public demand, political response, downstream consequences, and the recurring tendency to blame elected officials for results that were foreseeable from the start.

The goal is not to defend politicians or to argue that all criticism of government is misplaced. Many politicians do fail, act in self-interest, or make poor decisions. The goal is to highlight a structural problem that receives far less attention than it deserves: the gap between what voters ask for and what they are willing to accept as the cost of getting it.

Until more Americans develop a stronger habit of systems thinking — understanding that most policy choices involve trade-offs, delayed effects, and consequences that reach beyond any single community — the cycle will continue. Politicians will keep responding to the loudest short-term demands. Problems will keep emerging downstream. And the public will keep wondering why their elected officials can't seem to deliver the results they want.

This book is an invitation to look more carefully at that pattern — and to ask whether the real problem lies only with the politicians, or whether it also lies with the incentives created by the way we, the people, ask for things.

Chapter 1

Wages, Jobs, and the Cost of Good Intentions

For decades, one of the most consistent and politically popular demands from American voters has been for higher minimum wages. In city after city and state after state, candidates who promised rapid and repeated increases often gained strong support from large segments of the electorate. Those who resisted or urged caution frequently faced political backlash, primary challenges, or lost elections altogether. The message from many voters was clear and repeated over many election cycles: wages for lower-income workers should rise substantially, and elected officials should make it happen.

Politicians responded as democratic electoral incentives would strongly predict. To win office and retain power, many supported or actively championed higher minimum wages. Some cities and states implemented annual increases well above the federal level, sometimes reaching fifteen dollars per hour or more within just a few years. On the surface, these policies appeared to represent a clear victory for working families and a fulfillment of voter demands.

However, the economic effects on businesses — particularly small businesses operating on thin margins — were more complex and often more negative than many voters and policymakers anticipated or publicly acknowledged at the time.

When labor costs rise significantly and on a relatively compressed timeline, businesses face a limited set of difficult choices. Some attempt to raise prices to offset the higher wages, which can reduce sales volume, especially in

price-sensitive industries such as retail and food service. Others cut employee hours, reduce non-wage benefits, or slow the pace of new hiring. Many accelerate investment in automation — self-service kiosks, automated ordering and payment systems, robotic kitchen equipment, and other labor-saving technologies — in order to reduce their dependence on human workers over time. Still others relocate operations to lower-cost regions within the United States or, in some cases, move production or services overseas entirely.

The result in numerous communities has been a measurable reduction in entry-level and low-skill job opportunities, particularly in retail, food service, hospitality, and small-scale manufacturing. Young workers, those with limited formal education or work experience, and individuals re-entering the workforce after periods of unemployment or incarceration often find fewer available positions than existed previously. In several major cities that implemented aggressive minimum wage increases, multiple studies documented slower job growth or outright job losses in low-wage sectors compared to similar metropolitan areas that maintained more modest wage policies during the same period.

At the same time, many of the same people who had strongly supported rapid and substantial wage increases began to notice the shrinking number of available jobs and the greater difficulty of finding stable, full-time employment at the lower end of the labor market. Rather than connecting these outcomes directly to the wage policies they had demanded and voted to support, large numbers turned their frustration and disappointment toward politicians. They asked why elected officials had allowed businesses to close or relocate, why jobs had disappeared from their communities, or why economic conditions seemed to be deteriorating for working families despite the higher mandated wages.

This pattern is not limited to minimum wage laws alone. Similar dynamics have appeared when communities demanded heavy new regulations on local businesses, significantly higher taxes targeted at employers, or expansive new labor mandates such as strict paid leave requirements, rigid scheduling rules, or costly workplace standards. Politicians responded to these pressures by passing the requested measures, often with strong public support at the time. Some businesses were able to absorb the added costs through higher prices or improved efficiency. Others reduced staff, delayed planned expansions, raised prices more aggressively than they otherwise would have, or ultimately left the jurisdiction. Jobs and local tax revenue declined in many cases. The public then frequently blamed politicians for the resulting economic difficulties — rarely pausing to consider seriously that the original demands had contributed meaningfully to the outcome.

The underlying issue across these examples is fundamentally the same: voters tend to focus intensely on the immediate, visible benefit (higher pay for some current workers, or stronger legal protections) without fully accounting for how businesses will respond over time in a competitive market economy. When businesses respond in predictable ways that reduce employment opportunities, slow hiring, increase prices, or shift operations elsewhere, the public experiences the downside of those adjustments and attributes the problems primarily to political failure or corporate greed rather than to the original policy choices they supported.

This does not mean that all wage increases or worker protection measures are inherently harmful or counterproductive. Modest, gradual adjustments that businesses can reasonably absorb over time often produce limited negative side effects while delivering meaningful benefits to workers. The recurring problem arises when demands become aggressive, frequent, and politically enforced without adequate consideration of economic

trade-offs and business responses.

Politicians operate under intense electoral pressure in these situations. Resisting popular proposals for higher wages, stronger mandates, or new regulations carries real and immediate political risk, including the possibility of losing the next election. Many therefore choose to deliver what large numbers of voters are actively demanding, even when they privately recognize that the likely downstream consequences may include job losses, business closures, or slower economic growth in their communities. When those consequences appear, the same voters who created the original pressure often hold the politicians responsible for failing to prevent the negative outcomes.

This cycle — strong public demand, political compliance, business adjustment and adaptation, negative economic or employment effects, and subsequent public blame directed at elected officials — repeats across multiple policy areas with remarkable consistency. It is not usually caused by politicians simply ignoring the will of the people. It is frequently caused by politicians responding too closely and too quickly to what significant portions of the electorate asked for, without the public fully understanding or being willing to accept the full chain of economic effects that would follow from those demands.

In the chapters that follow, we will see this same fundamental pattern play out in energy and infrastructure policy, housing, healthcare, education, immigration, entitlement programs, public safety, and foreign policy. The specific details and policy areas change, but the core dynamic remains remarkably consistent across domains: voters demand visible, immediate benefits or protections; politicians respond to electoral pressure; predictable trade-offs and adjustments emerge over time; and the public tends to blame elected officials for results that were foreseeable from the original demands.

Chapter 2

Energy, Infrastructure, and the Price of Progress

One of the most visible contradictions in modern American life is the public's simultaneous demand for advanced technology and resistance to the infrastructure required to support it. This tension is especially clear in the growing conflict over data centers.

Americans expect — and increasingly demand — faster internet, seamless streaming, powerful AI tools, instant cloud services, and smart devices that work reliably. When services slow down or new capabilities are delayed, frustration is immediate and vocal. Yet when companies announce plans to build the physical facilities that make these technologies possible — large data centers filled with servers and powerful cooling systems — local communities frequently organize strong opposition.

Residents and local politicians often cite noise from cooling fans, high electricity and water consumption, increased traffic, or changes to the local landscape. In response to this pressure, many politicians block permits, impose strict regulations, or publicly campaign against the projects. At the same time, the same public continues to demand better and faster digital performance.

When companies shift new data center construction to other states or countries with fewer restrictions, or when existing facilities become overloaded, the consequences appear as higher costs, slower innovation in some regions, or degraded service quality. When the internet feels slower, cloud services glitch, or new AI features are limited, many people direct their frustration at politicians and technology

companies — rarely connecting the outcome back to the widespread local resistance to the very infrastructure that powers modern technology.

This is a clear example of concentrated costs versus diffuse benefits. The burdens of a data center (noise, energy use, visual impact) are highly visible and felt locally. The benefits (faster services, economic growth, and national technological competitiveness) are spread across millions of users who do not directly experience the downsides. Voters feel the immediate pain of a data center in their community far more acutely than the gradual costs of slower technological progress.

The same pattern appears across other areas of energy and infrastructure.

Communities across the country frequently resist new power plants, natural gas facilities, nuclear projects, or high-voltage transmission lines due to concerns about visual impact, perceived safety, or local environmental effects. At the same time, the public expects reliable electricity for homes, electric vehicles, data centers, manufacturing, and everyday life. When blackouts occur, electricity prices rise, or reliability suffers, blame is directed at politicians rather than at the earlier resistance to building sufficient capacity.

A similar dynamic plays out with renewable energy. There is broad public support for solar and wind power in principle. Yet specific projects often face intense local opposition over land use, wildlife concerns, noise, or changes to scenic views. The result is slower deployment than promised, continued reliance on other energy sources, and higher costs — followed by criticism of politicians for failing to deliver a rapid transition.

Even efforts to secure the materials needed for modern technology and green energy reveal the same pattern. The push for electric vehicles and advanced electronics requires large increases in mining for lithium, cobalt, copper, and rare

earth elements. Domestic opposition to new mines, often driven by environmental concerns, leads to greater reliance on foreign sources. When supply chain disruptions occur or prices rise, the public frequently blames politicians or corporations rather than the earlier resistance to domestic production.

In each of these cases, voters and local politicians prioritize avoiding immediate, visible local costs. They expect the benefits of reliable energy, advanced technology, and economic growth without fully accepting that someone, somewhere, must host the infrastructure that makes those benefits possible. When problems emerge — higher costs, slower progress, or reduced reliability — the blame predictably shifts upward to elected officials.

Politicians face a difficult position. Approving contentious projects risks angering local voters. Blocking or delaying them contributes to broader problems that eventually generate complaints from a wider public. Many choose the path of least immediate political resistance.

This cycle is not caused by politicians ignoring the people. It is often caused by politicians responding to the strongest local demands while the larger public continues to expect the benefits those demands make more difficult to deliver.

The fundamental issue is a widespread reluctance to accept trade-offs. People want the advantages of modern technology and abundant, reliable energy. They are far less enthusiastic about accepting the infrastructure, mining, power generation, and transmission facilities required to support those advantages. When the system struggles to meet expectations, the public rarely reflects on its own role in creating the constraints. Instead, it blames the politicians who were navigating those constraints.

This pattern of demanding progress while resisting the foundations of progress appears in many areas beyond

energy and technology. It helps explain why certain problems persist even when politicians attempt to respond to public pressure. Until more people develop a clearer understanding of the connections between what they want and what must be built or allowed to support it, the cycle of demand, resistance, disappointment, and blame is likely to continue.

Chapter 3

Housing, Rent Control, and Homelessness

Few issues generate stronger public emotion than housing costs and homelessness. Across many American cities, voters have demanded stronger rent control laws, expanded tenant protections, and aggressive measures to keep housing “affordable.” Politicians have responded by passing rent control ordinances, strict eviction rules, and additional regulations on landlords and new construction.

On the surface, these policies appear to protect tenants from rising costs and displacement. In practice, however, they often produce the opposite of the intended effect over time.

When rent control limits how much landlords can charge, many property owners find it unprofitable to maintain or improve their buildings. Some convert rental units into condominiums or other uses. Others simply stop investing in maintenance. New investors become reluctant to build rental housing in areas with strict rent control because the potential returns are limited. The result is a reduction in the overall supply of rental housing.

At the same time, strong tenant protections and lengthy eviction processes increase the risk and cost of being a landlord. Some property owners sell their buildings or exit the rental market entirely. With fewer units available and new construction slowed by both regulation and reduced profitability, competition for the remaining housing intensifies. Rents in uncontrolled units often rise faster than they otherwise would have.

The people most affected by these dynamics are frequently those with the least resources. As the supply of affordable and mid-tier rental housing shrinks, low-income individuals and families face longer wait times, higher costs in the remaining market, and greater difficulty finding stable housing. In many cities that have implemented aggressive rent control and tenant protection measures, homelessness has increased rather than decreased.

When homelessness rises and housing becomes harder to find, the public often directs its frustration at politicians. They ask why elected officials have allowed the crisis to worsen, why more housing isn't being built, or why rents continue to climb despite new protections. The same politicians who passed the rent control and tenant protection laws that voters demanded now face blame for the resulting shortage and displacement.

This pattern reveals a common failure to think through second- and third-order effects. Voters focus on the immediate goal of protecting current tenants from rent increases. They are far less focused on the long-term impact on housing supply, new construction incentives, and the ability of the market to respond to growing demand. When the predictable shortage emerges, the blame falls on politicians rather than on the policies that reduced the incentive to provide housing.

Similar dynamics appear in other housing-related demands. Strong opposition to new housing developments, often framed as protecting neighborhood character or the environment, frequently slows or blocks new construction. At the same time, the public continues to demand more affordable housing and criticizes politicians when shortages persist. The combination of rent control, tenant protections, and resistance to new building creates a powerful constraint on supply while demand continues to grow.

Politicians face significant pressure on both sides. Local residents often oppose new development in their neighborhoods. At the same time, broader public opinion demands solutions to rising rents and homelessness. Many elected officials respond by supporting popular tenant protections and rent control measures while struggling to overcome local resistance to new housing. The result is a system that makes it increasingly difficult to expand supply in response to need.

The core issue is not that protecting tenants is inherently wrong. Reasonable tenant protections and gradual policies can coexist with a healthy housing market. The problem arises when demands become one-sided — strong protections and rent limits without corresponding efforts to maintain or expand supply — and when the public expects the benefits without accepting the trade-offs required to sustain them.

Until voters and local communities are willing to support both tenant protections and the construction of new housing, the cycle of shortage, rising costs, and blame is likely to continue. Politicians cannot create more housing by regulation alone. They can only create the conditions under which the market has incentives to build it. When those incentives are removed or heavily restricted, the supply of housing tends to stagnate while demand grows.

This chapter illustrates the same underlying pattern seen in wages and energy infrastructure: public demands for immediate relief or protection often produce consequences that are predictable but rarely fully considered at the time the demands are made. When those consequences appear, the public tends to blame politicians rather than re-examine the original policy choices.

Chapter 4

Healthcare Costs and Access

Few issues generate more consistent public frustration than the cost of healthcare in the United States. Voters across the political spectrum regularly demand lower prices, stronger price controls on drugs and procedures, expanded coverage mandates, and greater government involvement in the system. Politicians have responded over the years with a wide range of measures, including drug price negotiations, insurance mandates, expanded public programs, and various forms of regulation on providers and insurers.

Despite these repeated interventions, healthcare costs have continued to rise for decades, and many Americans still report difficulty accessing care or affording insurance. When costs remain high or access problems persist, the public often directs its anger at politicians for failing to solve the problem.

This pattern reveals a recurring gap between what voters ask for and the actual dynamics of the healthcare system.

When the public demands lower prices through regulation or price controls, providers and drug manufacturers face pressure to reduce revenue on certain services or products. In response, many shift costs to other areas — raising prices on less-regulated services, reducing unprofitable lines of care, or limiting investment in research and development. Some providers consolidate or leave certain markets entirely. Over time, this can reduce the supply of certain types of care or slow the development of new treatments.

At the same time, expanded coverage mandates and requirements that insurers cover more services without

corresponding increases in funding often lead to higher premiums or reduced plan options. Insurers respond to new mandates by adjusting benefits, networks, or pricing to maintain profitability. The result is frequently higher overall spending rather than the lower costs many voters expected.

When these adjustments occur and costs continue to rise or certain services become harder to access, the public tends to blame politicians for not doing enough. The same elected officials who passed the regulations, mandates, or expanded programs that voters demanded now face criticism for the system's ongoing problems.

A similar dynamic appears with demands for dramatically expanded government-run healthcare systems. Supporters often point to lower administrative costs or broader coverage in other countries. However, many of those systems also face significant challenges, including long wait times for non-emergency care, shortages of certain specialists, and limits on access to newer treatments. When similar pressures appear in proposals for large-scale U.S. systems, they are frequently downplayed during political debate.

Politicians who support expansive new programs face pressure to promise broad benefits without fully acknowledging the trade-offs in taxes, wait times, or innovation. When those trade-offs become visible after implementation, public disappointment often turns into blame directed at the politicians who championed the changes.

The core issue is not that Americans want affordable, high-quality healthcare — that desire is nearly universal. The difficulty lies in the public's tendency to demand lower costs and broader access while resisting the difficult choices required to achieve those goals sustainably.

Price controls and heavy regulation can reduce prices in targeted areas, but they often lead to cost-shifting, reduced

supply, or slower innovation elsewhere. Expanded coverage without corresponding changes in how care is delivered or paid for tends to increase overall spending. Systems that prioritize broad access and low out-of-pocket costs for patients often require other forms of rationing, such as wait times or limits on certain treatments.

Politicians operate in an environment where promising popular benefits is politically rewarded, while clearly explaining necessary trade-offs is often punished. As a result, many healthcare policies are designed more to satisfy immediate voter demands than to address the structural drivers of cost and access.

This chapter illustrates the same underlying pattern seen in previous examples. Voters focus on visible problems — high prices, insurance complexity, or gaps in coverage — and demand solutions that appear straightforward. Politicians respond with policies that address the most politically salient concerns. When the full effects of those policies emerge, including unintended consequences, the public frequently attributes the remaining problems to political failure rather than to the limitations of the original demands.

Until there is broader public willingness to accept the trade-offs inherent in sustainable healthcare reform — whether those involve changes in how care is delivered, how it is paid for, or how much is spent — the cycle of high costs, access challenges, policy interventions, and recurring blame is likely to continue.

Chapter 5

Education Funding and Outcomes

Education is one of the most consistently funded areas of American public policy, yet it remains one of the areas where results frequently disappoint voters. For decades, the public has demanded increased spending on schools, smaller class sizes, better teacher pay, and specific curriculum or pedagogical approaches. Politicians have responded with higher budgets, new programs, and various reforms.

Despite significant increases in per-pupil spending over the past several decades, national test scores in reading and math have remained largely stagnant in many measures, and large achievement gaps persist. When results fall short of expectations, the public often blames politicians for “underfunding” education or failing to implement the right policies.

This pattern reveals a recurring disconnect between inputs and outcomes in education policy.

Voters and advocacy groups frequently focus on visible inputs — more money, smaller classes, or particular teaching methods — without fully accounting for how those resources are used or the many non-financial factors that influence student achievement. When additional funding does not produce proportional improvements, frustration grows and blame is directed at elected officials.

A similar dynamic appears with curriculum and instructional changes. Strong public or activist pressure sometimes leads to rapid adoption of new teaching approaches, content standards, or ideological frameworks with limited broad consensus or long-term evidence. When parents and communities later object to the content or

methods, or when results do not improve as promised, politicians who supported the changes face backlash.

In both cases — funding increases and curriculum shifts — the public often expects clear, positive results from policy changes while underestimating the complexity of education. Student outcomes are influenced by family background, community factors, student behavior, teacher quality, and instructional methods. Simply increasing spending or changing standards does not automatically overcome these deeper variables.

Politicians face pressure from multiple directions. Teachers' unions and education advocates push for more funding and specific policies. Parents and taxpayers demand better results and accountability. When politicians increase spending without corresponding improvements, they are criticized for waste. When they attempt to tie funding to performance or push controversial curriculum changes, they face opposition from other groups. The result is often a cycle of increased spending, policy experimentation, disappointing outcomes, and renewed blame.

This chapter illustrates the same underlying pattern seen throughout the book. Voters focus on immediate, visible demands — more money for schools or particular content — without fully considering the complex system that determines educational results. Politicians respond to the strongest pressures. When outcomes fall short, the public attributes the failure primarily to political shortcomings rather than to the limitations of the original demands or the difficulty of the underlying challenge.

Sustainable improvement in education outcomes requires more than increased funding or frequent policy changes. It requires realistic expectations about what policy alone can achieve, honest assessment of what works, and willingness to address non-school factors that heavily influence student success. Until public demands better account for these

realities, the cycle of increased spending, policy churn, and recurring disappointment is likely to continue.

Chapter 6

Immigration, Borders, and Labor Markets

Immigration policy is one of the most emotionally charged and politically divisive areas in American public life. Voters on different sides of the issue regularly demand expansive immigration policies, sanctuary city measures, pathways to citizenship for large numbers of people in the country illegally, or significantly reduced enforcement at the border. Politicians have responded over the years with various combinations of amnesty programs, expanded legal immigration, and periods of lax enforcement.

At the same time, many of the same communities that support expansive immigration policies also express strong concerns about wages, job opportunities for native-born workers, pressure on housing and public services, and cultural integration. When these pressures become visible, the public often blames politicians for failing to manage immigration effectively.

This pattern reveals a recurring gap between policy demands and their economic and social consequences.

When large numbers of low-skilled immigrants enter the labor market, basic economic principles suggest downward pressure on wages in certain sectors, particularly for workers without college degrees. Studies from various periods have shown modest to significant wage effects for high school dropouts and workers in construction, agriculture, food service, and other low-skill industries. Employers gain access to cheaper labor, while some native-born workers face increased competition.

At the same time, rapid population growth from immigration increases demand for housing, schools, healthcare, and other public services. In many high-immigration areas, this has contributed to higher housing costs and greater strain on local budgets. When these effects become noticeable, the same public that supported more open immigration policies often directs frustration at politicians for rising costs of living or declining quality of public services.

Politicians face conflicting pressures. Advocacy groups and business interests often push for higher immigration levels and more lenient enforcement. At the same time, many voters express concern about wage competition, fiscal costs, and cultural cohesion. When politicians attempt to satisfy one set of demands, they frequently alienate the other. The result is often inconsistent policy, periods of lax enforcement followed by crackdowns, and recurring public disappointment.

A similar dynamic appears with sanctuary policies. Cities and states that limit cooperation with federal immigration enforcement often do so in response to strong local political pressure. When this leads to high-profile incidents involving individuals with criminal records who were released rather than transferred to federal authorities, public outrage frequently targets the politicians who supported or maintained those policies.

The core issue is not whether immigration is inherently good or bad. Reasonable people can disagree about appropriate levels and selection criteria. The recurring problem is that many voters demand policies with significant economic and social consequences without fully accounting for those consequences in advance. When the downsides become visible — wage pressure for some workers, fiscal strain on communities, or public safety incidents — the blame is directed at politicians rather than at the original policy preferences.

This chapter illustrates the same underlying pattern seen throughout the book. Public demands for expansive immigration or reduced enforcement create predictable effects on labor markets, public services, and social cohesion. Politicians respond to the strongest political pressures. When negative consequences emerge, the public tends to attribute them primarily to political failure rather than to the trade-offs inherent in the original demands.

Until there is broader public willingness to acknowledge the full range of effects from immigration policy — both benefits and costs — and to support consistent, sustainable approaches rather than contradictory demands, the cycle of policy inconsistency, visible problems, and recurring blame is likely to continue.

Chapter 7

Entitlements, Debt, and Future Generations

One of the most significant long-term challenges facing the United States is the growing burden of entitlement programs — primarily Social Security and Medicare — and the national debt that supports them. For decades, the public has supported expanding benefits, protecting current levels of support, and adding new programs without corresponding increases in revenue. Politicians have responded by maintaining or increasing benefits while often avoiding the difficult choices required to keep the systems solvent.

Social Security and Medicare were designed as pay-as-you-go systems, where current workers fund current retirees. As the population ages and the ratio of workers to retirees declines, these programs face growing funding shortfalls. Without reforms, they are projected to require either substantial tax increases, significant benefit cuts, or both in the coming decades.

Despite repeated warnings from actuaries and budget analysts, the public has shown little appetite for meaningful reform. Voters strongly oppose cuts to current or near-term benefits. At the same time, they often resist tax increases needed to sustain the programs. Politicians, responding to these pressures, have largely maintained the status quo, allowing the unfunded liabilities to grow.

When the day of reckoning approaches — when trust funds are depleted and automatic benefit reductions or tax increases are triggered — the public is likely to blame the politicians in office at that time. Yet those politicians will largely be responding to the accumulated decisions of

previous generations who demanded benefits without paying for them fully.

This represents one of the clearest examples of intergenerational transfer in American policy. Current and near-retirees receive benefits that exceed what they paid into the system, while younger workers and future generations face the prospect of higher taxes and lower benefits to sustain the programs. Many younger Americans are already skeptical that Social Security and Medicare will be there for them in their current form.

A similar dynamic appears with proposals for new universal programs or significant expansions of existing ones. Strong public support often exists for ideas like expanded paid family leave, universal pre-K, or other new entitlements. Politicians who support these initiatives gain political credit. However, the long-term fiscal impact is frequently understated during the political debate. When costs prove higher than projected or when future budgets become constrained, the public tends to blame current politicians rather than the original decision to create or expand the programs without sustainable funding.

The core issue is the public's preference for immediate benefits over long-term fiscal responsibility. Voters want generous entitlements and low taxes simultaneously. Politicians who attempt to reconcile these incompatible demands by borrowing or deferring costs are later blamed when the debt becomes unsustainable or when future adjustments become necessary.

This chapter illustrates the same underlying pattern seen throughout the book, but with particularly long time horizons. Public demands for expanded or protected benefits create predictable fiscal pressures that fall disproportionately on future generations. Politicians respond to current voter preferences. When the accumulated consequences become unavoidable, the public blames the politicians of that era

rather than recognizing the role of earlier policy choices.

Sustainable entitlement reform requires honest acknowledgment of demographic realities and the need for adjustments in benefits, taxes, or both. Until the public is willing to accept that current benefit levels cannot be maintained indefinitely without corresponding revenue increases, the cycle of expanding commitments, growing debt, and eventual painful adjustments — followed by blame — is likely to continue.

Chapter 8

Policing, Crime, and Public Safety

Public safety is one of the most fundamental responsibilities of government, yet it has become one of the most volatile areas of policy debate. Following high-profile incidents involving police use of force, strong public pressure often emerges for reduced policing, lower budgets for law enforcement, bail reform, and more lenient prosecution policies. Politicians in many cities responded to these demands in the years following 2020 by cutting police budgets, restricting certain policing tactics, and supporting progressive prosecutors who emphasized reduced incarceration.

In several major cities that implemented significant reductions in proactive policing or changes in prosecution, violent crime — particularly homicide — rose sharply in 2020 and 2021. Many of these cities later saw partial reversals, with increased funding for police and tougher prosecution policies as crime concerns grew among residents.

When crime rises, businesses close or relocate, residents feel less safe, and quality of life declines. The public then frequently blames politicians for failing to maintain order. Yet many of the same politicians who faced criticism for rising crime had been responding to earlier, equally strong public demands for reduced policing and criminal justice reform.

This represents a particularly clear example of the demand-and-blame cycle. After high-profile incidents, voters and activists demanded changes that reduced the intensity of law enforcement in many urban areas. When those changes

correlated with rising crime, the public turned against the politicians who had implemented the reforms. The same dynamic has appeared in earlier periods of American history when crime waves led to political backlash against officials perceived as soft on crime.

The underlying issue is the public's tendency to react strongly to visible incidents without fully considering the broader consequences of policy changes. Demands to "defund the police" or dramatically reduce prosecutions were often framed as addressing systemic problems. When crime increased and affected the daily lives of residents — particularly in lower-income neighborhoods — the political support for those policies eroded quickly.

Politicians face intense pressure from different directions. After high-profile incidents, activist groups and media coverage push for reform. When crime rises, residents and business owners demand action. Politicians who move too far in either direction risk backlash. The result is often policy oscillation — periods of reduced enforcement followed by crackdowns — rather than stable, effective approaches to public safety.

This chapter illustrates the same underlying pattern seen throughout the book. Public demands for policy changes in response to visible problems create predictable effects. When those effects include increased crime or disorder, the public tends to blame the politicians who responded to the earlier demands rather than re-examining the original policy preferences. The cycle of incident → reform pressure → policy change → negative consequences → blame repeats across different eras and different cities.

Sustainable public safety policy requires balancing accountability for law enforcement with the need for effective policing. It also requires honest recognition that reducing proactive policing and prosecution tends to increase crime, particularly in vulnerable communities. Until public

demands better account for these trade-offs, the cycle of reform, backlash, and recurring blame is likely to continue.

Chapter 9

Environmental Policy and Energy Reliability

Environmental policy is one of the areas where public demands and political responses most clearly illustrate the gap between intentions and outcomes. Voters across much of the political spectrum express strong support for cleaner air and water, reduced carbon emissions, and a transition to renewable energy. Politicians have responded with aggressive targets for reducing fossil fuel use, subsidies for renewable energy, restrictions on new domestic energy production, and various forms of regulation on traditional energy sources.

While these policies have contributed to improvements in air quality in many areas, they have also produced significant challenges in energy reliability and cost. In several states and regions that moved aggressively toward renewable energy while restricting traditional sources, electricity prices have risen substantially, and reliability concerns have increased. Periods of low wind or solar generation have led to reliance on backup sources or, in some cases, rolling blackouts or emergency alerts.

At the same time, public opposition to new domestic oil, gas, nuclear, or mining projects remains strong in many areas. This opposition often stems from legitimate local environmental concerns. However, it also contributes to greater reliance on foreign energy sources and critical minerals, many of which are produced under weaker environmental and labor standards than would be required domestically.

When energy prices rise or reliability issues emerge, the public frequently blames politicians for failing to deliver affordable, reliable energy. Yet many of the same politicians who face criticism had been responding to strong public and activist pressure for rapid decarbonization and restrictions on traditional energy development.

This represents another clear example of the demand-and-blame cycle. The public wants cleaner energy and lower emissions. It also wants affordable and reliable power. When policies prioritize one goal at the expense of the other, the public experiences the downside and attributes the problem to political failure rather than to the inherent trade-offs in the original demands.

A similar pattern appears with mining and manufacturing needed for the green energy transition. The push for electric vehicles, batteries, and renewable infrastructure requires large increases in mining for lithium, cobalt, copper, and rare earth elements. Domestic opposition to new mines often leads to greater reliance on foreign sources. When supply chain issues arise or environmental damage occurs overseas, the public tends to blame corporations or politicians rather than the earlier resistance to domestic production.

Politicians face difficult choices. Supporting rapid decarbonization and restrictions on traditional energy earns support from environmental advocates. Supporting new domestic energy production and mining earns support from those concerned about jobs, costs, and energy security. When politicians attempt to balance these competing demands, they often satisfy neither side fully. When problems emerge, blame is directed at the politicians rather than at the contradictory nature of public demands.

This chapter illustrates the same underlying pattern seen throughout the book. Public demands for aggressive environmental policies create predictable effects on energy costs, reliability, and supply chains. Politicians respond to

the strongest political pressures. When negative consequences become visible, the public tends to blame the politicians who responded to the earlier demands rather than re-examining the original policy preferences or acknowledging the trade-offs involved.

Sustainable environmental policy requires honest recognition of trade-offs between emissions reductions, energy affordability, reliability, and domestic production. Until public demands better account for these realities, the cycle of ambitious targets, implementation challenges, higher costs or reliability issues, and recurring blame is likely to continue.

Chapter 10

Foreign Policy, Alliances, and Public Demands

Foreign policy and national security represent some of the most complex areas where public demands and political responses frequently diverge in their long-term effects. Voters often express strong preferences for reduced overseas military involvement, lower foreign aid, or skepticism toward international alliances and commitments. Politicians have periodically responded to these pressures with troop withdrawals, reduced engagement, or attempts to renegotiate alliances.

However, the United States has long benefited from a global system of alliances, trade routes, and security commitments that support its economic interests and way of life. The petrodollar system, for example, has historically tied global oil trade to the U.S. dollar, helping maintain demand for American currency and supporting the country's ability to finance its debt at relatively low costs. When countries challenge or opt out of arrangements that support this system, it can create significant economic and strategic pressure.

When the public demands reduced involvement abroad or questions the value of alliances, politicians face pressure to scale back commitments. This can weaken deterrence against adversaries, increase risks to global trade routes that supply critical resources, or reduce American influence in key regions. When these risks materialize — through supply disruptions, higher energy prices, or increased global instability — the public often blames politicians for foreign policy failures.

This represents another clear example of the demand-and-blame cycle. The public wants lower military spending, fewer overseas entanglements, and reduced foreign aid. It also expects stable energy prices, secure supply chains, and a relatively peaceful international environment that supports American prosperity. When policies that reduce engagement contribute to greater instability or economic pressure, the public tends to blame the politicians who responded to the earlier demands rather than acknowledging the trade-offs involved.

A similar pattern appears with foreign aid and international institutions. Voters often express skepticism about sending money overseas or participating in multilateral organizations. Politicians who support these commitments face domestic criticism. Yet many of these arrangements have historically supported American strategic interests, trade access, and influence. When withdrawing or reducing support leads to loss of leverage or increased influence by rival powers, the public frequently criticizes politicians for weak foreign policy.

Politicians operate under intense cross-pressure in foreign policy. Domestic audiences often prefer lower costs and less involvement. International realities, however, frequently require sustained engagement to protect economic interests and deter adversaries. When politicians attempt to reduce commitments in response to public pressure, they risk creating power vacuums or weakening deterrence. When problems later emerge, blame is directed at the politicians rather than at the original public preference for reduced engagement.

This chapter illustrates the same underlying pattern seen throughout the book, applied to foreign policy and national security. Public demands for reduced overseas involvement or lower costs create predictable strategic and economic effects. Politicians respond to the strongest domestic pressures. When negative consequences become visible —

whether through higher energy costs, supply chain disruptions, or increased global instability — the public tends to blame the politicians who responded to the earlier demands.

Sustainable foreign policy requires honest recognition that American prosperity has long depended on a degree of global engagement and security commitments. Until public demands better account for the connection between overseas involvement and domestic economic interests, the cycle of pressure for reduced engagement, strategic consequences, and recurring blame is likely to continue.

Conclusion

Throughout this book, we have examined a consistent pattern in American politics: voters demand visible benefits or protections, politicians respond to those demands, predictable consequences emerge, and the public then blames elected officials for the results.

We saw this cycle in wages and employment, where aggressive minimum wage increases sometimes led to job losses and automation, followed by blame directed at politicians. We saw it in energy and infrastructure, where resistance to data centers, power plants, and mining projects coexisted with demands for better technology and reliable energy. We saw it in housing, healthcare, education, immigration, entitlements, public safety, and foreign policy.

In each case, the core issue was the same. Large numbers of voters focused on immediate, short-term desires without fully accounting for long-term trade-offs. Politicians, operating under electoral pressure, often delivered what was asked for. When the downstream effects appeared — higher costs, fewer jobs, reduced reliability, or unintended social consequences — the public rarely reflected on its own role in creating those outcomes. Instead, it blamed the politicians.

This pattern is not primarily caused by corrupt or incompetent elected officials. It is caused by a structural misalignment between what voters demand in the short term and what is required for sustainable, long-term governance. Democratic systems reward politicians who respond to current public pressure. They do not automatically reward those who make difficult choices whose benefits may not appear for years.

Breaking this cycle requires more than better politicians. It requires a more informed and systems-thinking public. Voters must be willing to ask not only “What do I want right

now?” but also “What are the likely consequences of getting it?” They must be willing to accept that most meaningful policy choices involve trade-offs, and that demanding one benefit often requires accepting costs somewhere else.

This does not mean people should stop advocating for better wages, cleaner energy, affordable housing, or good schools. It means they should advocate with a clearer understanding of how the world actually works. When voters demand contradictory things — lower taxes and more services, aggressive decarbonization and cheap reliable energy, strong tenant protections and abundant new housing — politicians will continue to deliver half-measures and the public will continue to feel disappointed.

The real problem in American politics is not just the politicians. It is also the people who elect them and the incentives those people create. Until that changes, the cycle of demand, response, consequence, and blame will continue.